Army suing for peace. That suited the Burmese commander, for his main objective was to plunder the country and take the loot back to Burma. Three years later, the Ahoms were at it again, the Burmese-installed Chandrakanta Singha having been deposed by Purinder Singh. Once again this brought the Burmese into play, and they reinstalled Chandrakanta. This time around, the Burmese had other plans for Assam and they refused to withdraw, imposing a rule of terror on the countryside. This period came to be known as the 'manor din' in Assamese and 'chahi-taret khungtakpa' in Manipuri—seven years of devastation. The situation was soon untenable even for Chandrakanta, who yet again turned to the British for help.

Though outwardly the East India Company appeared reluctant to intervene in Assam's affairs, the Madras and Bengal armies planned a two-pronged assault under the command of Sir Archibald Campbell who then invaded Burma through the Arakan Coast and Rangoon. A third smaller force assembled at Golpara and moved upriver along the Brahmaputra into Assam. The Burmese invasion, a long hard battle of attrition, lasted two years until Bodawpaya sued for peace. As part of the settlement, the kingdom of Assam was handed over to the British (Manipur and Tripura remained independent kingdoms).

After a few years of direct rule, parts of Upper Assam were returned to Purinder Singh. This arrangement was to last until 1839 when the British decided to expand their domain and set into motion a series of annexations. Purinder Singh was deposed on grounds of 'misrule' and Assam became a part of Bengal. It was only in 1919 (under the Government of India Act) that Assam was designated as a separate province. The British, when they moved in, looked at Assam as a unit of India as a whole. This resulted in a more stable administration and more importantly, an infusion of fresh ideas that would transform the region completely. Perhaps the most important step was the planting of the first tea garden by Robert Bruce at the mouth of the Kundil River near Sadiya in 1832. With unlimited land at their disposal, tea planters went to work clearing forests and soon most of Assam was growing tea.

The flat plains of the Brahmaputra and Surma river valleys were hemmed in from all sides by densely forested mountain ranges: the Himalayas to the north, the Naga-Patkai and Manipur Hills to the east, the Lushai Hills to the south and the Jaintia, Khasi and Garo ranges in the centre. Inhabited by tribes of various hues, the plains were at their mercy, as